

SHOWDOWN

A betting game between bots. You write one HTTP endpoint; our server deals, runs the betting and calls you whenever it's your turn.

No card-game experience needed. Everything you need is on this page — if you've never played a betting game before, start at the top and read straight down. Every term is defined where it first appears, and again in the [glossary](#) at the bottom.

The challenge runs in phases across the day. **The rules on this page hold in every phase.** Each phase adds one twist on top, and its own guide covers only that twist — so read this page once, then just the guide for the phase you're on.

Phase	Points
Phase 1 guide	300
Phase 2 guide	400
Phase 3 guide	600
Phase 4 guide	400 (bonus)

The basics

You play **matches**. A match is a run of **hands**, and every hand works the same way: everyone is dealt a secret number, players take turns betting chips, and the best number at the end takes all the chips that were bet.

- **Chips** are what you win and lose. Everyone starts a match with **200**.
- The **pot** is the pile of chips bet so far in the current hand. Whoever wins the hand takes the pot.
- Your **stack** is what you have left to bet with. It carries from hand to hand — win one and it grows, lose one and it shrinks.
- Your **chip delta** is your score: chips up or down against the 200 you started with. Finish on 230 and your chip delta is +30.

How one hand works

1. **Forced bets.** Before anything is dealt, two players have to put chips in: one puts in **1**, the other puts in **2**. Nobody chooses this — it exists so every hand has chips worth playing for. Who pays which alternates every hand, so the cost is shared evenly. That 2 counts as a real bet, so in the first betting round there is always something to match. (On the wire these are `small_blind` and `big_blind`; poker calls them *blinds*.)
2. **The deal.** Everyone gets one secret **number** from **1 to 13**. Each is drawn independently, so both players holding the same number is common.
3. **Betting round 1** (`pre_reveal`).
4. **The reveal.** One shared **community number** is made public, drawn the same way from 1 to 13.
5. **Betting round 2** (`post_reveal`), now that everyone can see it.
6. **Showdown.** Everyone still in the hand shows their number and the best one takes the pot.

Who wins at showdown

- If your number **equals the community number** you have a **pair**, and any pair beats any non-pair. That's the big one.
- Otherwise the **higher number wins**.
- Identical results **split the pot**.

If the other player folds, you win the pot immediately and **nothing is shown** — not your number, not the community number. You never have to prove you had anything, which is exactly why bluffing works.

(If you do know poker: this is no-limit hold'em with one number per player instead of two cards, and one community card instead of five.)

Taking your turn

There are only five actions:

Action	What it does
	Pass without betting. Only possible when there's nothing to match, so

check	it's free.
call	Put in enough to match the current bet and stay in the hand.
bet	Open the betting when nobody has bet yet this round.
raise	Put in more than the current bet, so the other player must match it or fold.
fold	Give up the hand, and the chips you already put in.

We send a `legal_actions` list on every turn and it is **authoritative** — reply with one of those and you cannot make an illegal move. `fold` only appears when someone has bet at you, so you can't accidentally throw away a hand that would have been free to see through.

Bet sizing

The game is **no-limit**: there is no cap on bet size. Your stack is the only ceiling.

`bet` and `raise` need an `amount`, and `amount` is the **total you will have put in for that betting round** once the action completes — not the extra on top. If you've already put in 6 this round and want to add 18 more, send `24`. Raise **to** 24, not **by** 24.

Keep `amount` inside `[min_raise_to, max_raise_to]`. We send both on every request, already accounting for your stack and the minimum-raise rule, so you never have to work them out. If the two are equal, betting your whole stack is the only raise you can afford — and it is legal.

Putting your entire stack in is going **all-in**. If your opponent bets more than you can cover you can still call for everything you have and play for the part of the pot you matched; chips you couldn't cover go back to them.

Position — who acts when, and how it rotates

Seats are fixed for the whole match. `your_seat` is yours, and `players` comes back in seat order.

Each hand, one seat holds the **button** (`button_seat`) — a marker that decides who pays which forced bet and who acts in what order. It moves to the other seat every hand.

	seat 0	seat 1 [BUTTON]
forced bet	2	1
acts pre_reveal	2nd (last)	1st (first)
acts post_reveal	1st (first)	2nd (last)

- The **button pays the smaller forced bet** (1) and acts **first** before the reveal.
- After the reveal that flips: the button acts **last**, having watched the other player first. Acting last is an advantage — you decide with more information.
- The seat without the button pays 2, acts last before the reveal, and first after it.

The order is **not** the same in both betting rounds. That reversal is the part that trips people up, so read the diagram twice.

The button alternates every hand, which is what keeps it fair:

hand 12	button seat 0	pays 1: seat 0	pays 2: seat 1
hand 13	button seat 1	pays 1: seat 1	pays 2: seat 0
hand 14	button seat 0	pays 1: seat 0	pays 2: seat 1

You never have to work the order out yourself — we call you when it's your turn. But `button_seat` tells you which side of that table you're on this hand, which is what makes `current_hand_actions` readable: the same opponent plays very differently depending on whether they're acting first or last.

Scoring and busting

Everything is scored on **chip delta**, sent every request as `chip_delta`. Hit 0 chips and you're **busted**: you're out, however many hands were left, and your chip delta is a flat -200.

Your bot

One endpoint. We handle dealing, betting and timing.

POST {your_base_url}/move

Called whenever it's your turn. Request body:

```
{
  "protocol_version": 2,
  "match_id": "phase1-seed7",
  "phase": 1,
  "table_rule": "standard",
  "small_blind": 1,
  "big_blind": 2,
  "starting_stack": 200,
  "your_stack": 185,
  "hand_number": 6,
  "total_hands": 100,
  "round": "post_reveal",
  "your_number": 3,
  "community_number": 5,
  "your_seat": 0,
  "button_seat": 1,
  "pot": 32,
  "to_call": 18,
  "min_raise_to": 36,
  "max_raise_to": 185,
  "legal_actions": ["fold", "call", "raise"],
  "players": [
    {
      "seat": 0,
      "name": "you",
      "folded": false,
      "chip_delta": -8,
      "bet_this_round": 0,
      "stack": 185,
      "all_in": false,
      "busted": false
    },
    {
      "seat": 1,
      "name": "Gaston",
      "folded": false,
      "chip_delta": 8,
      "bet_this_round": 18,
      "stack": 183,
      "all_in": false,
      "busted": false
    }
  ],
}
```

```

"current_hand_actions": [
  { "round": "pre_reveal", "seat": 1, "action": "raise", "amount": 7 },
  { "round": "pre_reveal", "seat": 0, "action": "call", "amount": 7 },
  { "round": "post_reveal", "seat": 0, "action": "check" },
  { "round": "post_reveal", "seat": 1, "action": "bet", "amount": 18 }
],
"recent_hands": [
  {
    "hand_number": 2,
    "community_number": 13,
    "winners": [1],
    "pot": 24,
    "shown_numbers": { "0": 9, "1": 11 },
    "actions": [
      { "round": "pre_reveal", "seat": 1, "action": "raise", "amount": 5 },
      { "round": "pre_reveal", "seat": 0, "action": "call", "amount": 5 },
      { "round": "post_reveal", "seat": 0, "action": "check" },
      { "round": "post_reveal", "seat": 1, "action": "bet", "amount": 7 },
      { "round": "post_reveal", "seat": 0, "action": "call", "amount": 7 }
    ]
  }
]
}

```

Reading that: seat 1 holds the button, so you're on the 2-chip forced bet. Seat 1 raised to 7 before the reveal and you called. The community number came out 5, you checked, seat 1 bet 18 into a pot that now holds 32, and it's your turn holding a 3 — no pair, no straightforward call.

Field	What it tells you
<code>your_number</code>	Your secret number this hand, 1–13.
<code>community_number</code>	The shared number. <code>null</code> before the reveal.
<code>round</code>	<code>pre_reveal</code> (before the shared number) or <code>post_reveal</code> (after).
<code>pot</code>	Chips already in the middle, waiting to be won.
<code>to_call</code>	Chips you must add to stay in. <code>0</code> means checking is free.
<code>min_raise_to</code> / <code>max_raise_to</code>	Legal range for <code>amount</code> ; both <code>null</code> if you can't bet or raise.

<code>your_stack / starting_stack</code>	Chips you have left, and what everyone began the match with.
<code>small_blind / big_blind</code>	The two forced bets, 1 and 2.
<code>your_seat / button_seat</code>	Your seat number, and which seat holds the button this hand — together they tell you your spot in the acting order.
<code>table_rule</code>	Which showdown ruleset the match is using.
<code>hand_number / total_hands</code>	Where you are in the match.
<code>match_id</code>	Stable for the whole match — key your own state off this if you keep any.
<code>players[].stack</code>	That seat's live remaining chips, updating within the hand.
<code>players[].chip_delta</code>	Frozen at the start of the hand, unlike <code>stack</code> .
<code>players[].bet_this_round</code>	Chips they've put in this round — this is where the forced bets show up.
<code>all_in / busted</code>	Out of chips <i>this hand</i> (still live for showdown) vs. out of the <i>match</i> .
<code>current_hand_actions</code>	Every action so far this hand.
<code>recent_hands</code>	The last 20 completed hands: winners, pots, numbers shown at showdown, full action logs.

Two things worth knowing:

- **amount in the action logs** is that seat's round total after the action — present for `bet / raise / call`, absent for `check / fold`. The forced bets aren't actions and never appear there; read `bet_this_round` instead.
- **players is a list in seat order**, and you're always in it under the name `"you"`. Read it as a list rather than assuming a fixed shape, and **ignore any field you don't recognise** — we add fields over the course of the event and never remove them.

Respond within **5 seconds** with HTTP 200:

```
{"action": "raise", "amount": 24}
```

Omit `amount` for `check`, `call` and `fold`. A missing or out-of-range `amount` is **not** clamped for you — it counts as an illegal move.

GET `{your_base_url}/health` (optional, recommended)

Return HTTP 200. We use it as a warm-up before a match so a cold start doesn't eat your first move. Without it we fall back to an `OPTIONS` probe against `/move`.

When things go wrong

A timeout, a bad response, an illegal action or a bad `amount` gets substituted with `check` (or `fold` if checking isn't legal). Five in a row forfeits the match. We never retry a `/move` call, so keep it fast and side-effect-free.

You're never told another player's number before showdown, or anything about matches other than your own.

Running an attempt

Deploy anywhere reachable over HTTPS — a local server behind a tunnel (`cloudflared tunnel --url http://localhost:5000`, `ngrok http 5000`) is fine. The coordinator runs an attempt against your registered URL and reports your score. One attempt at a time per team, with a short cooldown between.

Retry as often as you like: **your best single attempt counts** for each phase.

Watching a match

Every finished attempt is replayable, and your result comes back with a link to it. Two ways in:

- [Replay viewer](#) — `/game/<runId>` deep-links straight into one of your runs, or drop a match file onto the page. It walks each hand step by step: the table, every bet, the reveal, the showdown, plus a chip chart and the final standings.
- `/matches/<runId>` — the same match as raw JSON, with the complete hand log: every hand, every action, and the numbers every player was actually dealt. Take

the replay link you were given and swap `/game/` for `/matches/` ; add `?download=1` on the end to save it as a file. Parse this one if you want to go through your matches with code rather than by eye.

Runs are held in memory only. They're lost if the server restarts, and older ones are eventually dropped to make room, so save anything you want to keep.

Glossary

Every term used on this page, in one place. Terms in `code font` are fields or values you'll see on the wire.

Term	Meaning
Hand	One full round of play: forced bets, deal, betting, reveal, betting, showdown. Also loosely "the number you were dealt".
Match	A fixed number of hands played back to back, with stacks carrying across them.
Chip	The unit of money. Everyone starts a match with 200.
Stack (<code>your_stack</code>)	Chips you have left to bet with, right now.
Pot (<code>pot</code>)	Chips already bet this hand. The winner of the hand takes them.
Chip delta (<code>players[].chip_delta</code>)	Your score: chips up or down against the 200 you started the match with.
Busted (<code>players[].busted</code>)	Stack hit 0. You're out for the rest of the match.
All-in (<code>players[].all_in</code>)	You've put your entire stack in. You can't act again this hand, but you still play for the part of the pot you covered.
Forced bets (<code>small_blind</code> , <code>big_blind</code>)	The 1 and 2 chips the two players must put in before each deal, alternating every hand. Poker calls them <i>blinds</i> .

Your number (<code>your_number</code>)	The secret 1–13 you were dealt. Nobody else sees it before showdown.
Community number (<code>community_number</code>)	The shared 1–13 revealed midway through the hand. <code>null</code> before the reveal.
Pair	Your number equals the community number. Any pair beats any non-pair.
Reveal	The moment the community number is made public, splitting the hand into two betting rounds.
Betting round (<code>round</code>)	<code>pre_reveal</code> (before the community number) or <code>post_reveal</code> (after).
Showdown	The end of a hand where everyone still in shows their number and the best one wins the pot.
Recent hands (<code>recent_hands</code>)	Rolling window of the last 20 completed hands, newest last. Each entry is a whole finished hand: <code>hand_number</code> , <code>community_number</code> , <code>pot</code> , <code>winners</code> , <code>shown_numbers</code> and the full <code>actions log</code> . Resets at the start of every match.
Winners (<code>recent_hands[][winners]</code>)	The seat numbers that won that hand and took the pot.
Shown numbers (<code>recent_hands[][shown_numbers]</code>)	The numbers laid on the table at showdown, keyed by seat. Only seats that got there appear — a hand won by a fold shows nothing, and that hand's <code>community_number</code> is <code>null</code> too if it ended before the reveal.
Recent-hand actions (<code>recent_hands[][actions]</code>)	Same shape as <code>current_hand_actions</code> .
Fold / check / call / bet / raise	The five actions. See Taking your turn .

to_call	Chips you must add right now to stay in. 0 means checking costs nothing.
Raise to (current_hand_actions[].amount)	Bet sizes are stated as the total you'll have in <i>for that round</i> , not the extra on top.
No-limit	No cap on bet size; your stack is the only ceiling.
Button (button_seat)	The seat marker that sets the forced bets and the acting order. Moves to the other seat every hand.
Position	Where you sit in the acting order relative to the button. Acting last after the reveal is an advantage, and the rotation shares it out evenly.
Bluff	Betting a weak number to make a better number fold. Works because a hand won by folding never reveals anything.
Table rule (table_rule)	Which showdown ruleset a match uses.
Attempt	One run of a phase against your registered bot URL. Retry freely; your best attempt counts.